

19. The suspicion is not without basis—Kaziranga Park guards, too, use .315 rifles. “Such baseless allegations demoralise the dedicated force of forest guards at Kaziranga. The .315 rifle is not a prohibitive bore and anyone with a licence can procure bullets for the weapons,” says Rockybul Hussain, minister for environment and forests. In fact, this allegation created widespread resentment among security guards who work in most primitive conditions in the park with months away from families. Hussain has even demanded a CBI inquiry into the incident. “I have written to Chief Minister Tarun Gogoi to ask CBI to probe the killing of rhinos to clear any doubt,” he says. Hussain, who has been in the line of fire of several political parties and organisations for the unabated killing of rhinos in the park, constituted a committee last month headed by Forest Commissioner B.B. Hagier to chalk out an action plan to curb the menace. The committee submitted its report to the chief minister on February 1 and reiterated what the state forest policy had said in 2004. It took the Government four years and the killing of several rhinos to be reminded of its own policy.

The committee pointed out that an inadequate number of guards was a major reason for poaching. Rapid growth of shrubs that choked grass, use of sophisticated weapons by poachers, rise in the number of other animals and increase in the area of the park were the reasons listed in the report for the decimation of the rhinos. The committee also recommended regular recruitment of forest guards, setting up of a special task force exclusively for Kaziranga and granting of national reserve forest status to the adjoining reserve forests. As the park has no fencing or a boundary wall, poachers easily enter at night and lay traps on the paths frequented by rhinos. The rhino’s unique habit of defecating at a particular spot for days together also helps poachers identify its path. “KNP’s

EASY PREY

Despite a global ban on its trade, there is a thriving market for rhino horns



The price of a rhino horn in India varies from Rs 4 lakh to Rs 7 lakh and its value in the international market is between Rs 12 lakh and Rs 20 lakh, says an NGO Nature’s Beckon. The horn of an Asian rhino commands a higher price than that of its African counterpart. In Yemen, rhino horns are carved into ceremonial dagger handles known as *jambiyas*. Before Yemen banned the import of rhino horn in 1982, it was its world’s largest consumer, importing more than 2,700 kg every year—about 40 per cent of the total trade. In traditional Chinese medicine, rhino horn is used to treat fever, delirium, high blood pressure and other ailments.

area has increased to 859 sq km from the original 430 sq km in 1974 but a corresponding increase in manpower has not been affected,” says Hagier.

Following these recommendations, the Government initiated steps for setting up new forest camps along NH 37, repaired some of the existing ones and procured 200 .303 rifles. A proposal was passed to raise the number of security guards to 2,600 from the existing 510. However, the guards will have to make do with outdated weapons. “The arming of guards with sophisticated weapons is not simple. Several legal and technical issues will have to be considered. The process will take time,” says the forest minister.

However, these measures may not be adequate if people living on the fringes of the park are not involved, says Bibhab Kumar Talukdar, noted environmentalist and secretary general of Aaranyak, an NGO. “The intelligence network in the fringe villages must be foolproof. The cooperation of the locals is very important,” he adds. Talukdar does not believe in the allegation that park officials are in league with poachers and points out that these are the same men, who had been hailed for, what was claimed as the biggest wildlife conservation success story of the last century. “The problem lies with the top management. The current director had no experience in wildlife preservation before he took up

the job,” says Talukdar.

The increasing availability of arms and ammunition to unlawful elements is also contributing to poaching. Ammunition recovered from the site confirms that poachers are using a wide variety of weapons, some of which could have been acquired from extremist outfits. Hussain sees a conspiracy with the involvement of militant groups. His claims find corroboration from the most unlikely corner—poachers themselves. “Naga militants are directly involved in the poaching racket. They gave us sophisticated weapons to hunt the animal,” a former poacher told INDIA TODAY on condition of anonymity. He now helps the KNP authorities combat the menace.

The one-horned Indian rhino (*rhinoceros unicornis*) is an endangered species and is protected under Indian Wildlife Protection Act 1972. It has been listed in Schedule I of the Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species. Its horn is in great demand globally, particularly in Southeast Asia, and is used in traditional medicines and also as an aphrodisiac. But Dr Samiran Malla Buzarbaruah, a Guwahati-based veterinarian, rubbishes the claim that rhino’s horns have medicinal values. “The horn is a mass of agglutinated hair and is meant for the animal’s defence. There is no scientific proof that the horn powder can enhance sexual desire or prowess,” he says.

It is ironic that the main weapon of defence of this beautiful animal has become the biggest chink in its armour and leaves it vulnerable to human greed. ■



“A CBI probe will bring out the actual picture of what is going on inside the park.”

ROCKYBUL HUSSAIN, MINISTER FOR ENVIRONMENT AND FORESTS